ALPR Council and Community Engagement Guide

AXON

A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR AGENCY PREPARATION, COUNCIL APPROVAL AND LONG-TERM GOVERNANCE

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Foreword

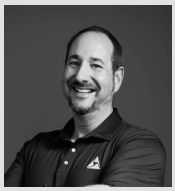
Dear Public Safety Partners,

Public safety technology earns its legitimacy through governance, not just capability. Agencies that can explain not only what a product does but how it is governed walk into every public hearing on solid ground. That work starts before a product reaches the field. Axon's Responsible Innovation Framework guides how we evaluate emerging technologies and helps ensure expanding capability does not outpace accountability.

The Ethics & Equity Advisory Council, a body of community leaders and subject-matter experts in civil rights, criminal justice reform, AI ethics, public policy and social equity, provides an external perspective that shapes our approach to product development, including the ALPR capabilities this guide addresses.

That is the standard we built into it. We design our systems so agencies own and control their data. Sharing is off by default, explicit, visible and revocable. Retention and access follow agency-defined controls. Activity is logged so oversight is enforceable. That governance model is reflected in how we build.

This guide is built to help agency leaders explain those governance choices in their own voice in the rooms where it matters, including council chambers, community meetings and conversations with civic stakeholders.



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Note: This foreword is provided by Axon. The agency's case for its ALPR program should be made in the agency's own voice, using the companion Q&A and other toolkit materials.

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Why This Guide Exists

A council vote on an automated license plate recognition (ALPR) program is a governance decision before it is a technology decision. The questions that decide the room are not answered by detection rates or camera counts alone. They are about who controls the data, who can see it, what happens when someone outside the agency requests access, and what shows the agency is operating the way it said it would. An agency that can answer those questions with built-in controls and reviewable records is prepared to have a productive conversation about how the program is governed.

This guide is built for that. It helps agency leaders explain who controls the data, who can access it and how the program is reviewed. The companion toolkit helps agencies turn that foundation into local answers, checklists and proof sources.

The Questions That Decide the Room

Most ALPR hearings turn on a small set of questions. The questions below will help you prepare direct answers, and the next section shows the architecture behind each one.

What does the system collect, and what does it leave out?

Each detection captures a license plate image, a vehicle context image, basic vehicle attributes such as color, make and vehicle type, and the time and location. Context images provide vehicle context for review. They are not used for facial recognition, driver identification or behavioral profiling. The system does not perform live registered-owner lookups when a plate is read.

Who owns the data, sets retention and controls access?

The agency does. The agency owns its ALPR data, sets retention periods, controls user access and decides whether and how sharing is enabled. Those are agency decisions. The system applies the configured controls, and the agency remains responsible for policy, training and oversight.

Can another agency see this data, and does sharing create a national pool?

Sharing is off by default and requires the owning agency's deliberate approval. Another agency can access data only through a specific sharing relationship approved by the owning agency. That access is invite-only, visible and revocable. Sharing creates no national pool, no copy of agency ALPR data and no transfer of ownership. A recipient agency cannot re-share ALPR data it receives through a sharing relationship.

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THE QUESTIONS THAT DECIDE THE ROOM – CONTINUED

Can the system be used to follow people or vehicles over time?

The system does not monitor people or maintain a live location feed. When investigating a specific vehicle, an authorized user can review prior detections of that plate within the agency's retention period. That search is tied to a named user and logged with the action, time and stated reason.

What happens if a federal agency or outside party seeks agency ALPR data through Axon or directly from the agency?

Through Axon, there is no automatic, standing or built-in federal access to agency ALPR data. Because the agency owns and controls the data, a lawful request goes to the agency and its counsel to handle. If Axon receives such a request, Axon directs it to the agency as the data owner and discloses data only where legally required to do so.

What record shows the program is operating within policy?

The audit record does. Access, searches, sharing activity where enabled and configuration changes are logged and available for agency review. When sharing is enabled, that record includes recipient activity against shared data and changes to sharing relationships over time. The companion Audit & Accountability Checklist helps agencies turn those logs into a repeatable oversight process.

The rest of this guide explains what makes these short answers enforceable, so the agency can point to the controls, records and decision rights behind each claim before the hearing forces the question.

How the Architecture Answers Them

This section shows the architecture behind each of those questions, the system controls that apply the agency's decisions and the records that let the agency verify them.

What the system collects, and what it does not

The collection boundary is defined by what the system is designed to capture: vehicle detection information, not driver identity. The context image gives reviewers visual information around the vehicle. Because it is an image from the scene, it may incidentally include surroundings, signage or people in view. It is not analyzed for facial recognition or behavioral profiling, and its retention follows the agency's policy for ALPR detection data. The system does not perform live registered-owner lookups when a plate is read, does not independently retrieve personal records about individuals and does not build a profile of a registered owner. Identifying who is associated with a vehicle is a separate, deliberate step an agency takes through its own authorized channels, outside this system. Agency policy governs that step. The system maintains that separation by design, while access and activity are logged so the agency has a record it can review.

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HOW THE ARCHITECTURE ANSWERS THEM – CONTINUED

Who owns the data, sets retention and controls access

Retention settings are applied by the system on the schedule the agency sets for ALPR detection data. Data subject to that policy is automatically removed when the applicable retention period expires. Detections preserved as evidence follow the agency's evidence retention rules. Access is scoped to the users and roles the agency authorizes. The governance is the agency's. The system applies those controls and records activity so the agency can review use against policy.

Why sharing does not create a national pool

In pooled or network-based models, exposure can expand when visibility, copies or downstream access extend beyond what the originating agency can see or control. The agency-controlled model is built around a different boundary. Visibility changes only when the owning agency changes it. The sharing relationship stays visible to the owner and revocable, and agency ALPR data is not copied into a shared repository or routed into a national pool. The owning agency keeps ownership throughout. Because sharing does not copy the data or transfer ownership, a recipient agency cannot re-share ALPR data it receives through a sharing relationship.

Why historical lookup is not live tracking

Detection is automated. Operational judgment remains human. Investigative search reaches backward into records the agency already holds under its own policy, for an authorized purpose, tied to a named user and bounded by the agency's retention period. It is architecturally different from continuous tracking. There is no persistent watch on a person, no live feed that follows an individual across locations, and no system action that substitutes for human judgment.

What happens when an outside or federal entity wants the data

Agency ALPR data is not placed into a national or pooled database that outside entities can access through Axon. The agency remains the data owner and decision-maker. Because the agency owns and controls the data, a lawful request goes to the agency and its counsel to handle. If Axon receives such a request, Axon directs it to the agency as the data owner and discloses data only where legally required to do so.

These boundaries are enforced through system design, configuration controls and reviewable records. The next section explains how those records support the agency's accountability case.

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The Accountability Record

A governance case is only as strong as the record behind it. The boundaries in the previous section are supported by system controls, configuration choices and reviewable records an agency can use to show how the program is operating. That record is what helps separate a program governed in practice from a program described in policy alone.

The accountability record starts with the audit log. Access, searches, sharing activity where enabled and configuration changes are recorded and available to the agency. When sharing is enabled, the audit record includes recipient activity against shared data and changes to sharing relationships over time, so the agency can review who had access during a specific period. The log helps answer the questions an oversight body asks after a program is running: which user took which action, the timestamp and the stated reason for access. It is the difference between telling a council the program is used appropriately and being able to show the activity record behind that statement.

A log supports accountability when the agency reviews it consistently. That is the work the companion Audit & Accountability Checklist is built for. It gives the agency a repeatable model: who owns the audit function, how often access and activity are reviewed, what a review looks for and how exceptions are handled. An agency that can describe its review cadence and name its audit owner walks into a hearing with an operating oversight process, not just a system capability. The capability is in the system. The discipline of using it belongs to the agency.

The public transparency portal is a separate mechanism with a different job. Where the audit log is the agency's internal accountability record, the portal is a public-facing disclosure tool that lets an agency publish information about its ALPR program for community visibility. It supports the agency's public transparency approach, which is the agency's decision to make. It is a way to show the public the shape of the program. It is not the accountability mechanism itself. The audit record is.

For current security and certification documentation, trust.axon.com is the source. It holds Axon's published security and compliance materials and is the right reference when a council or city attorney asks about the platform's security posture. It documents how the platform is secured and independently assessed. It is not where an agency points to demonstrate its own governance decisions. Those live in the agency's policy, configuration choices and audit record. The next section steps back from the governance case to the platform itself.

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The Components and How They Connect

ALPR is the category most council members recognize. Axon Vehicle Intelligence is the name for five connected components anchored in Fusus, the real-time operations layer.

Fleet 3	Axon's mobile ALPR solution, capturing detections from patrol vehicles in the field.
Axon Outpost	A fixed ALPR camera with integrated livestreaming and flexible mounting options.
Axon Lightpost	Fixed ALPR and livestreaming on existing streetlights, through Axon's partnership with Ubicquia.
Works With Axon	A certified partner program that connects qualifying third-party cameras into the same workflow. Certification means a device has met Axon's security, performance and interoperability standards. The program grows as new partners qualify.
Axon Fusus Vehicle Search	The search and real-time operations capability inside Fusus where vehicle detections from mobile, fixed and certified partner sources come together.

Fusus is the real-time operations layer. It is where authorized users search and review vehicle detections under the agency's access controls. Relevant detections can be preserved in Axon Evidence, where they are retained and managed under agency-defined retention, access and audit controls.

Configured vehicle detection sources feed into one governed operations workflow. The agency controls who can access that workflow and how vehicle detections are retained, preserved and reviewed under agency-defined controls.

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The Companion Toolkit

This guide lays out the governance case. The companion documents help agencies prepare local answers, confirm decisions and maintain accountability over time. Each asset can be used as part of the full toolkit or shared independently once it has been reviewed and localized to the agency's deployment, policy and applicable law.

ALPR Program Details Worksheet	Captures your agency's deployment and policy decisions so every public answer reflects your actual program, not the general framework.
Axon Vehicle Intelligence Boundaries	What the platform does and does not do, in plain language for public discussions.
Council and Community Q&A	The questions a hearing is likely to raise, with answers you can localize to your agency.
Council Readiness Checklist	The governance decisions, owners and supporting documents to confirm before public discussion.
Audit & Accountability Checklist	A repeatable oversight process that helps the agency review audit logs, document outcomes and maintain an accountability record.

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THE COMPANION TOOLKIT – CONTINUED

Localize Before You Use It

The governance architecture in this guide is consistent across deployments. The agency-specific answers are not. Retention periods, sharing configuration, authorized uses and policy context are local decisions, and the toolkit answers need to reflect the decisions your agency has actually made. Before using any of the companion documents, localize the toolkit answers to your agency's:

Retention periods The actual retention window your agency has set for ALPR detection data.	**Sharing configuration** Whether sharing is enabled, with whom and under what approval.
Authorized uses The specific purposes your policy permits the system to be used for.	**Hotlist sources and approval process** Which lists your agency uses and who approves additions.
Audit owner and review cadence Who owns the audit function and how often access and activity are reviewed.	**Public transparency approach** Whether your agency publishes program information, what it publishes and where.
Federal and lawful request process How your agency handles a request for data, whether it arrives through Axon or directly.	**Livestreaming and recording settings, if enabled** Whether livestreaming or recording is enabled, who can access it and how video is retained.
Applicable state, local and public records law The statutes, ordinances and public records requirements that govern ALPR in your jurisdiction.	**Program outcomes, if available** Public-safe outcome examples your agency can speak to, such as recovered stolen vehicles, missing person responses or investigative leads.

Used together, the guide and companion documents give the agency a public explanation grounded in its actual policy, configuration and accountability record.

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Closing

ALPR programs play an important role in public safety, and they raise real questions from the communities they serve. A council vote comes down to a few of them: who controls the data, who can access it, what happens when someone outside the agency requests access and what records show the program is operating within policy. The answers in this guide are grounded in agency decisions, system controls and reviewable records. The agency owns its data, sets its retention, access and sharing rules, and can show how the program operates over time. Those are the answers to bring into the room.

Key Resources and Contacts

Axon Resources

Security and compliance documentation:
trust.axon.com

Vehicle Intelligence product overview:
axon.com/products/vehicle-intelligence

Responsible Innovation Framework:
axon.com/responsibility/responsible-innovation

Axon Contacts

Agency account support:
Contact your Axon account representative

Media and press inquiries:
press@axon.com

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